

Reflective Book Review 1

Philanthropy in the Muslim World: Majority and Minority Muslim Communities

By: Ardiansyah

Shariq A. Siddiqui and David A. Campbell's *Philanthropy in the Muslim World: Majority and Minority Muslim Communities* makes an important contribution to the study of Muslim philanthropy by challenging the dominance of Global North perspectives in philanthropic scholarship. Drawing on research from nineteen countries, the volume demonstrates that Muslim philanthropy is neither monolithic nor confined to a particular geography. Instead, it is shaped by diverse social, political, and cultural contexts while remaining rooted in shared ethical and religious principles.

A central contribution of the book is its broader understanding of philanthropy. In the chapter "What is Muslim Philanthropy?", Siddiqui (2023) argues that conventional philanthropic studies often focus on financial giving and formal institutions, whereas Islamic traditions encompass a wider range of actions, including zakat, sadaqah, waqf, good intentions, acts of service, and even preventing harm. The country studies further illustrate how Muslim philanthropy operates across different governance systems, diaspora communities, and civil society environments. Together, these chapters reveal the importance of trust, local leadership, and social responsibility in sustaining philanthropic action.

As someone who has spent more than a decade working in Islamic philanthropy, humanitarian response, volunteers, and digital fundraising, I found this book both affirming and challenging. It made me reflect on how easily practitioners can reduce philanthropy to organizational metrics such as fundraising targets, donor acquisition, and program outputs. While these indicators remain important, the book reminded me that philanthropy is fundamentally a social ecosystem that produces trust, solidarity, and community resilience.

Latief's (2023) chapter on Indonesia resonated strongly with my professional experience. His discussion of Indonesia's culture of giving, the role of faith-based organizations, and the integration of zakat into sustainable development reflects realities I have witnessed directly. In humanitarian and community development work, I have repeatedly observed that successful initiatives are rarely driven solely by financial resources. Rather, they depend on trust, local ownership, volunteerism, and a shared sense of responsibility. This insight strengthened my appreciation of philanthropy not merely as resource mobilization, but as a form of social capital that enables communities to respond collectively to challenges.

The book also deepened my understanding of humanitarian leadership. Contemporary humanitarian discourse emphasizes localization, resilience, and community-led development. What this volume demonstrates is that these principles have long existed within Muslim traditions of zakat, sadaqah, and waqf. For me, the most valuable lesson is that effective leadership is not primarily about managing resources, but about cultivating trust, accountability, and meaningful community engagement.

Moving forward, I hope to apply these insights in digital fundraising, volunteer development, and community empowerment initiatives. Ultimately, this book reinforces my conviction that Muslim philanthropy should be recognized not only as a charitable practice, but also as a powerful framework for humanitarian leadership and sustainable social transformation.

References

Latief, H. (2023). Reconsidering Muslim philanthropy and sustainable development in Indonesia. In S. A. Siddiqui & D. A. Campbell (Eds.), *Philanthropy in the Muslim world: Majority and minority Muslim communities* (pp. 307–325). Edward Elgar Publishing.

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Reflections on Leadership, Trust, and Public Legitimacy

By: Ardiansyah

Halil Demir's *9 Myths About Muslim Charities* begins as a memoir but quickly becomes something closer to a governance argument: that Muslim charities are held back not primarily by weak fundraising or poor program design, but by narratives imposed on them from outside. Reading it forced me to reconsider an assumption I have carried through more than a decade in Islamic philanthropy.

Demir organizes the book around nine misconceptions he has spent two decades correcting in practice: that Muslim charities are treated like any other charity (they are not; banks routinely "de-risk" and close their accounts without cause); that Islam does not teach charity, but hatred; that these organizations secretly work against America; that Islam forbids helping people of other faiths; that they foment sectarianism; that they serve only their own ethnic communities; that they favor the powerful over the vulnerable; that they abandon their American identity abroad; and that they underrepresent Muslim women in leadership. Each myth is dismantled not through argument alone, but through lived, verifiable stories from the Zakat Foundation's own fieldwork.

For more than ten years working in Islamic philanthropy institutions, I tended to treat fundraising, governance, and digital innovation as the central challenges of organizational growth. This book unsettled that assumption. Demir shows, chapter after chapter, that a more fundamental challenge sits underneath all three: building and defending public legitimacy. An organization can have sound governance and still be starved of trust by a narrative it did not create.

This lands with particular weight alongside the case study I wrote earlier this term on the competition between BAZNAS and private zakat institutions in Indonesia, which treated trust and legitimacy largely as internal, structural questions of transparency and leadership. This book complements that case study by helping me understand that governance challenges are not only internal, but also shaped by external narratives and public perception. Humanitarian leadership, I now understand, is not only about managing aid, raising funds, and designing programs; it is equally about protecting institutional integrity, resisting stigma, and advocating for communities that are persistently misunderstood.

As General Manager of Baitulmaal Pondok Digital, I am currently building our digital fundraising infrastructure. Demir's book sharpened how I think about that work: trust, transparency, storytelling, and public support form a single chain, and weakening any one link

weakens the rest. I intend to treat transparency and narrative-building as governance functions in their own right, not as communications add-ons, and to carry this legitimacy-focused lens into my ongoing academic research on Islamic philanthropy.

Reflective Book Review 3: *Understanding Muslim Philanthropy*

Ardiansyah

Siddiqui, Wasif, and Hughes (2024) argue that the dominant definition of philanthropy as "voluntary action for the public good" (Payton & Moody, 2008) carries a Euro-American, largely Protestant genealogy that cannot contain Muslim giving. Because zakat is obligatory and much sadaqa is private and informal, Muslim practice collapses the voluntary/obligatory and public/private binaries on which that definition rests. The authors therefore propose understanding philanthropy as intentional choices that advance a person's relationship with God while serving the perceived common good (p. 24). They pursue this empirically through cross-national survey data, a topic model of 100,000 zakat tweets, survey work on sadaqa in Muslim America, and a legal history of the waqf.

Reading from Indonesia rather than the United States sharpened the book's relevance. Two findings unsettled me. First, the authors report that Muslims commonly prefer informal giving and remain hesitant to give through formal organizations (p. 8). Second, they contend that weak accountability and management technique are not the principal challenge facing the field; the greater danger is the rush to define philanthropy narrowly (p. 24). For someone whose work is to professionalize and digitize institutional fundraising, this is uncomfortable. It suggests that formalization may be answering a problem donor do not actually experience, and that each gain in efficiency risks displacing the ordinary, unmeasured acts the authors insist are also philanthropy.

The book does not, however, counsel retreat from institutions. Its analysis of zakat discourse online shows that mainstream charity talks centers on efficiency and governance, while zakat talks centers on the giver's spiritual standing (pp. 69-70). For leadership practice this is

directly actionable: our campaigns should be built in the second register rather than the first, and trust treated as a religious relationship rather than a conversion metric.

Academically, the book unsettles a definitional assumption I had treated as settled in my own case study on zakat legitimacy in Indonesia. Professionally, it reframes my responsibility at BaitulMaal Pondok Digital and the Digital Fundraising Academy: the task is not to make Muslim philanthropy resemble Western nonprofit practice, but to build institutions that earn trust on Islamic terms.

References

- Payton, R. L., & Moody, M. P. (2008). *Understanding philanthropy: Its meaning and mission*. Indiana University Press.
- Siddiqui, S. A., Wasif, R., & Hughes, M. A. (2024). *Understanding Muslim philanthropy*. Edward Elgar Publishing. <https://doi.org/10.4337/9781035337293>